

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART ONE · STORY

CHAPTER 2 · TIME

Time as the thing holding the film together

SUNSET BLVD. · THE ROAD WE DID NOT

Run Lola Run · 1998 · 80 min · dir. Tom Tykwer

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner, and this one went straight on.

SUNSET BLVD.

RUN LOLA RUN

NOT SELECTED

1998 · 80 min · dir. Tom Tykwer · German

Lola has twenty minutes to find a hundred thousand marks and save her boyfriend, and the film runs those same twenty minutes three separate times. It is the loop in its purest commercial form, where the clock resets instead of running out, so the tension stops being about whether time runs out and becomes about what changes on the next pass.

WHY IT WAS ON THE BALLOT

Against Dunkirk it makes the sharpest possible pair. One film runs three clocks of different lengths at once so they finish together. The other runs one clock three times over. Both are asking whether a story is a fixed shape or just one route through a much larger set of them.

THREE FACTS, NO SPOILERS

- **Twenty minutes, stretched to eighty.** Tykwer has said the film started from an image of a woman running, and the plan was to invert the usual proportion of a feature, taking roughly twenty minutes of action and letting it fill four times that length. The finished film runs eighty minutes.
- **The director is one of the three people who wrote the music.** The score is credited to Tom Tykwer, Johnny Klimek and Reinhold Heil, which is a rare arrangement, and it shows in how

tightly the cutting sits on the beat.

- **Two million dollars, and it opened America to German film.** Made for about two million, it took more than seven million in North America, which at the time put it among the ten highest grossing foreign language releases the United States had ever had. Audience Award at Sundance in 1999, and an Independent Spirit Award.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Four moments, framed the same way as the other road, so the ticking clock conversation happens while you are still watching.

FIRST THREE MINUTES

It tells you the rule twice before it starts

Two quotations arrive before anything moves. One is T. S. Eliot, *we shall not cease from exploration, and the end of all our exploring will be to arrive where we started*. The other is the German national football coach Sepp Herberger, *after the game is before the game*. Then a security guard talks straight down the lens, a football goes up, and the title comes out of the crowd.

A film about repetition opens by quoting a poet and a football manager saying the same thing in two different registers.

WHENEVER LOLA IS OFF SCREEN

The picture quality changes

Lola was shot on 35mm. A great deal of what happens away from her was shot on video, and some of what has already happened comes back as grainy black and white. Watch the image firm up the moment she walks into a room, and go soft and cheap again when she leaves it.

The format is doing character work. Worth asking whether the film thinks she is the only one in it who is fully alive.

She stops being a person and becomes a drawing

Every run starts the same way, down the same stairs, and the film hands that stretch to animation, where a drawn Lola runs a corridor of clock faces. It happens three times, and it is not identical three times.

The drawing is where the film tips its hand earliest, before anyone on screen knows the run has changed.

The photographs

Brush past somebody and the film stops dead and deals out a handful of stills of that person's entire future, in about two seconds. Same people every run, different futures each time, and they go by fast enough to miss.

This is the film's real argument, made in the margins rather than in the plot.

IF YOU TOOK THIS ROAD

- **Does anything carry over?** Lola starts each run from the same doorway. Decide whether she is learning, or whether the film is simply dealing the cards again, and notice which answer makes the ending land harder.
- **Whose clock is it?** Nothing in the film is actually counting down on screen the way Dunkirk counts. So work out where the twenty minutes is being kept, and what is standing in for a clock.

THE OLDEST RULE IN THE BOOK

ARISTOTLE DESCRIBED A HABIT

Writing about Greek tragedy around 335 BC, Aristotle noticed that a tragedy *"tries as hard as it can to exist during a single daylight period, or to vary but little."* He is describing a tendency in plays that already existed, the way you would say most pop songs run about three minutes, which is taking notes rather than issuing instructions.

ITALY TURNED IT INTO A LAW

In 1570, an Italian scholar named Lodovico Castelvetro published a translation of the *Poetics* with his own commentary attached, and in that commentary the observation hardened into a requirement, that a play must happen inside a single day. Joined with unity of place and unity of action it became the three unities, and it went out under Aristotle's name rather than Castelvetro's.

FRANCE ENFORCED IT FOR A CENTURY AND A HALF

French classical theatre made the unities the standard of serious drama, argued them in public, and treated the writers who ignored them as amateurs. For roughly a hundred and fifty years the most influential theatre in Europe ran on a deadline one man inferred from another man's notes.

Chapter one found the three act structure published as a rulebook in 1979, thirty seven years after *Casablanca* was shot without one. [Somebody found hundreds of years](#)

[before the rulebook](#)

THREE WAYS A FILM CAN RUN A CLOCK

What actually separates them is the relationship between *story time*, meaning how long the events take, and *screen time*, meaning how long you sit there. Dunkirk is doing more

than one at once.

ONE

THE DEADLINE

A time inside the story that somebody has to beat. Screen time stays free to compress or stretch, and the film cuts across the boring parts while the deadline holds.

High Noon · Apollo 13 · Speed

TWO

REAL TIME

Screen time and story time are locked to the same length. The film cannot cut forward, so it has to fill every minute it claims.

The Set-Up · Rope · Cléo from 5 to 7 · 24

THREE

THE LOOP

The same span of story time runs more than once, so the clock resets instead of running out, and the tension moves to what changes on the next pass.

Groundhog Day · Source Code · Edge of Tomorrow

○ STORY TIME ● SCREEN TIME

1 · THE DEADLINE



2 · REAL TIME



3 · THE LOOP



The fourth case is running more than one of these at once, which is what Dunkirk is doing.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Writers separate a *time lock* from an *option lock*. A time lock ends the story when the clock runs out. An option lock ends it when the character runs out of things to try, which can feel identical from the seat even though nothing is counting down. Worth deciding, somewhere in the second half, which one you are actually watching.

WHY THIS IS THE FILM FOR IT

Dunkirk is running three of these at the same time, at three different lengths, which means every cut is asking you to hold a position in three separate countdowns at once. Chapter one was about the shape a story is supposed to have. This one is about what happens when a film stops using shape to organise itself and starts using duration instead.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Academy records, BFI and university programme notes, contemporary trade reporting and interviews with the filmmakers. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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